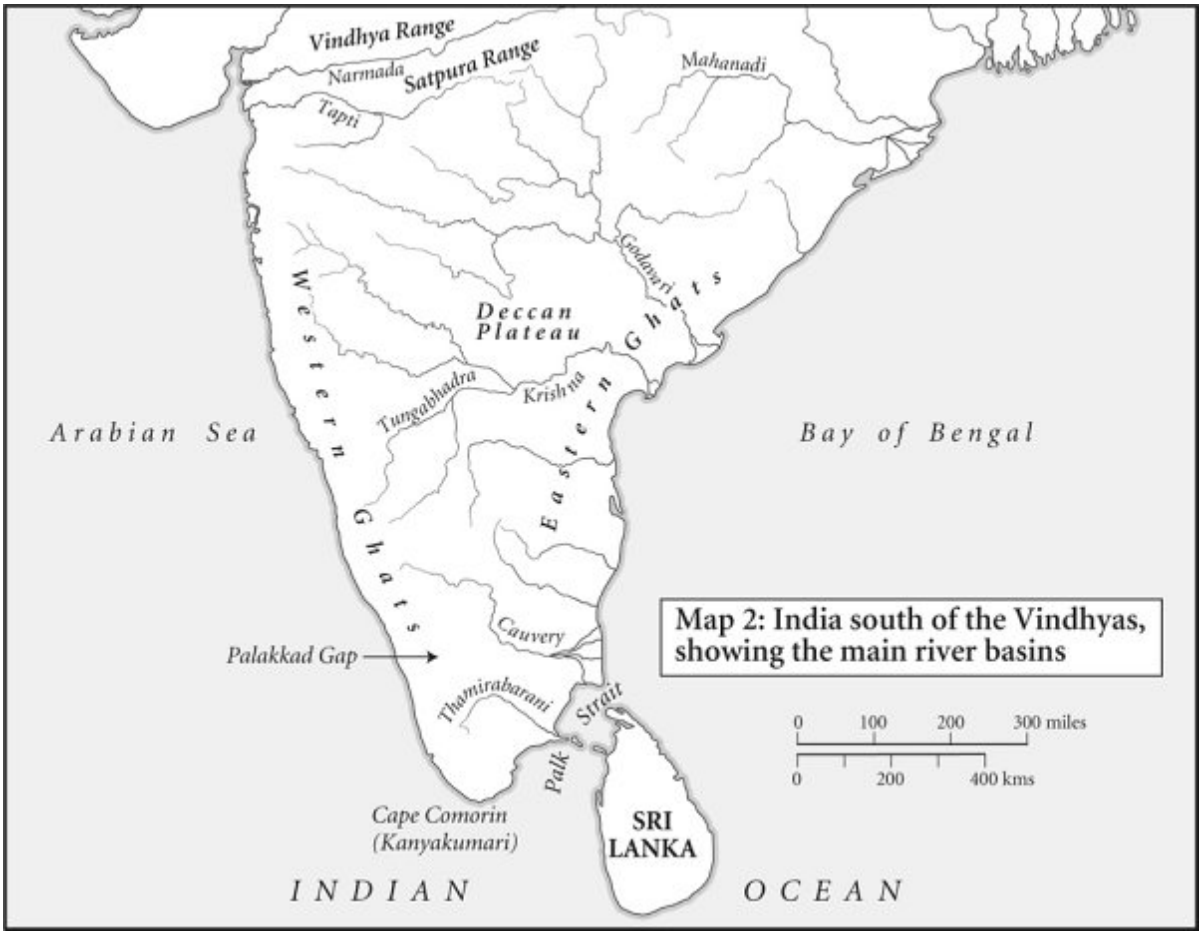
So you could say that the Deccan was born out of fire, Northern India out of water. The further north you travel the more unstable the land becomes, and vice versa. The only earthquakes in the South are the political ones.



Map 2: India south of the Vindhyas, showing the main river basins

But the Deccan is also a tilted tableland, with its highest elevation on the west, where a formidable mountain range extends north and south, rising in a series of *ghat*s or ‘steps’ from which it takes its name: the Western Ghats. Somewhat confusingly, they are referred to in Indian classical literature as ‘Malaya’, from the Tamil and Malayalam word for mountain, *malai*. ‘These hills,’ wrote one of the first British surveyors to explore them with a scientific eye, ‘are in terraces formed of horizontal strata of greenstone, amygdaloids, waskes and basalt. The most compact strata